

Excellence Health System

Appeal Request — Reconsideration of Adverse Determination

Patient Name: James Carter

DOB: 1962-08-12

MRN: 78214569

Original Denial Date: 2026-07-15

Member ID: MBR-00587

Appeal Filed Date: 2026-07-30

Appeal Level: Level 2 — External Independent Review

REASON FOR APPEAL

This is a Level 2 external appeal for reconsideration of the adverse determination issued on 2026-07-15 denying inpatient admission for Acute COPD Exacerbation (J44.1) with Acute Hypercapnic Respiratory Failure (J96.01).
The Level 1 internal appeal was denied on 2026-07-25.

CLINICAL RATIONALE FOR RECONSIDERATION

The prior reviews did not adequately consider the severity of this presentation:

- ABG: pH 7.28, pCO₂ 62 mmHg — severe respiratory acidosis
- O₂ Sat: 82% on room air, improving to 90% only on 6L nasal cannula
- WBC: 16.8 K/uL — leukocytosis suggesting superimposed infection
- Patient failed outpatient therapy (Azithromycin + Prednisone) for 3 days
- Required BiPAP within 2 hours of ED arrival
- History of 3 prior COPD exacerbation admissions in the past 12 months

POLICY REFERENCE

Per policy UM-COPD-001 (Acute COPD Exacerbation Admission):

- Criterion: Hypoxemia requiring > 4L supplemental O₂ — MET (6L NC required)
- Criterion: Acute respiratory acidosis (pH < 7.35) — MET (pH 7.28)
- Criterion: Failed outpatient therapy — MET (3-day course failed)
- Criterion: Need for non-invasive ventilation — MET (BiPAP initiated)

REQUESTED SERVICE

Inpatient admission to intermediate care / step-down unit for management of acute COPD exacerbation with respiratory failure, including IV steroids, continuous nebulizer treatments, BiPAP support, and infectious disease workup.

KEY EVIDENCE CITED

- ED Provider Note dated 2026-07-15
- ABG Results dated 2026-07-15
- Chest X-Ray dated 2026-07-15 showing hyperinflation
- Prior admission records (3 admissions in trailing 12 months)
- Outpatient prescription records showing failed therapy

FINANCIAL INFORMATION

Estimated cost of requested service: \$14,200.00

Diagnosis Category: Pulmonology — COPD

APPELLANT INFORMATION

Appellant Type: Provider

Attending Physician: Dr. James Mitchell, MD, Pulmonology

Contact: james.mitchell@excellencehealth.org | Phone: (555) 345-6789

GRIEVANCE STATEMENT

The patient's family has expressed a formal grievance regarding the original denial.

The family states the denial resulted in a 48-hour delay in treatment during which the patient's condition deteriorated, requiring eventual ICU-level care.

CONCLUSION

We request that the independent external reviewer overturn the denial. All clinical criteria under UM-COPD-001 are clearly met. The delay caused by this denial directly contributed to escalation of care and increased total cost of treatment.